

Rhetorical Failure & Mass Hysteria: Logical Fallacies Matrix in *The Crucible*

Author: Arthur Miller (1953) | Historical Context: The Salem Witch Trials & Cold War McCarthyism

Rhetorical Overview: In *The Crucible*, logical fallacies are not merely debating errors; they serve as procedural instruments of judicial violence and social coercion. Arthur Miller illustrates how a theocratic court—built on rigid dogma and fear—subverts formal logic to validate spectral evidence, enforce ideological conformity, and weaponize personal grievances. Studying these fallacious patterns reveals how corrupt authority constructs inescapable epistemic traps.

Section 1: Primary Logical Fallacies Present in *The Crucible*

Fallacy Type	Act & Character	Specific Textual Instance & Context	Rhetorical Analysis & Thematic Impact
Begging the Question (<i>Petitio Principii</i>)	Act III Judge Hathorne & Danforth	Hathorne to Martha Corey: <i>'How do you know that you are not a witch?'</i> Martha: <i>'If I knew what a witch was, I would know if I were one.'</i> Hathorne: <i>'If you do not know what a witch is, how do you know you are not one?'</i>	Hathorne assumes guilt in the premise. The court defines witchcraft as an invisible, unprovable crime where the only evidence is the victim's word. This circular logic creates an impossible defense: denying witchcraft is treated as proof of deceit.
False Dilemma (<i>Either/Or Fallacy</i>)	Act III Deputy Governor Danforth	Danforth: <i>'A person is either with this court or he must be counted against it, there be no road between.'</i>	Danforth eliminates all ideological nuance, framing dissent or skepticism as direct treason and demonic alignment. This parallels Cold War HUAC logic ('Either you are a loyal American or a Communist agent'), forcing citizens into blind compliance.
Ad Hominem (<i>Attacking the Person</i>)	Act III Rev. Parris & Ezekiel Cheever	When John Proctor brings Mary Warren's affidavit proving the girls are lying, Parris interjects: <i>'Such a Christian that will not come to church but once a month!'</i> Cheever adds: <i>'He plows on Sunday, sir.'</i>	Rather than addressing Proctor's evidence regarding the girls' fraud, the court's prosecutors attack his religious habits and character to invalidate his witness testimony and obscure institutional corruption.
Post Hoc Ergo Propter Hoc (<i>False Cause</i>)	Act I & II Ann Putnam & Walcott	1. Ann Putnam blames demonic forces for the deaths of her 7 infants. 2. Walcott claims Martha Corey bewitched his pigs because they die after he failed to feed them properly following a trade.	Characters mistake temporal sequence and unverified correlation for direct causation. Natural tragedy and personal negligence are reinterpreted through confirmation bias as supernatural malice.
Red Herring (<i>Emotional Distraction</i>)	Act III Abigail Williams	When Danforth pressures Abigail regarding Mary Warren's confession, Abigail suddenly screams, clutches herself, and claims to see a freezing 'yellow bird' sent by Mary to tear her face.	Abigail shifts the court's attention away from a dangerous logical cross-examination by staging a dramatic, panic-inducing spectacle. Fear and hysteria instantly derail rational inquiry.
Appeal to Authority (<i>Argumentum Ad Verecundiam</i>)	Act I Rev. John Hale	Hale arrives carrying heavy theological treatises: <i>'They are weighted with authority... Here is all your invisible world, caught, defined, and calculated.'</i>	Hale treats academic and ecclesiastical texts as infallible empirical proof. This reifies dogma, leading the community to trust flawed bureaucratic 'experts' over observed human reality.
Sunk Cost Fallacy (<i>Escalation of Commitment</i>)	Act IV Deputy Governor Danforth	Hale begs Danforth to pardon Proctor and Rebecca Nurse. Danforth refuses: <i>'I cannot pardon these when twelve are already hanged for the same crime. It links leaves a doubt upon the struggle.'</i>	Danforth refuses to admit error or alter course because doing so would invalidate past executions and destroy the court's prestige. Innocent lives are sacrificed to protect institutional ego.
Appeal to Fear (<i>Argumentum Ad Metum</i>)	Act I & III Abigail Williams & Danforth	Abigail to the girls: <i>'Let either of you breathe a word... I will come to you in the black of some terrible night and I will bring a pointy reckoning.'</i>	Coercion replaces truth. Witnesses testify not out of moral conviction or factual accuracy, but under direct physical and legal duress from both Abigail and the state.

Section 2: Fallacies Absent or Incompatible with Salem's Theocratic Structure

While *The Crucible* exposes numerous rhetorical breakdowns, certain informal and formal fallacies do **not** appear prominently in the play. Understanding *why* these fallacies are absent highlights the specific ideological conditions of 17th-century Puritan Salem.

Unaddressed Fallacy	Standard Definition & Typical Context	Rhetorical Reason for Absence in <i>The Crucible</i>
Appeal to Novelty (<i>Argumentum ad Novitatem</i>)	Claiming an idea or proposal is correct or superior simply because it is new, modern, or original.	Incompatible with Puritan Dogma: Salem society operates entirely on traditionalism and biblical orthodoxy. Any innovation, new idea, or deviance from ancient scripture is condemned as demonic heresy. Authority is derived strictly from the past.
Gambler's Fallacy	Assuming that past independent random events influence the probability of future random outcomes (e.g., 'a coin flip is due to land on heads').	Absence of Randomness in Worldview: Puritans do not believe in chance, luck, or statistical randomness. Every event—from a failed crop to a infant's sickness—is interpreted as deliberate divine providence or Satanic intervention.
Etymological Fallacy	Arguing that the present meaning of a word must strictly match its historical linguistic origin.	Lack of Academic Pedantry: The Salem trials are driven by visceral moral panic, ideological fear, and raw power dynamics, not technical linguistic analysis or semantic debates over word origins.
Tu Quoque (<i>'You Too' / Appeal to Hypocrisy</i>)	Attempting to discredit an opponent's argument by pointing out that they behave inconsistently or hypocritically.	Ineffectiveness Against Absolute Authority: While hypocrisy is rampant (e.g., Parris's greed), accused citizens cannot successfully defend themselves by saying 'you sin too.' The court claims divine mandate; pointing out judicial hypocrisy leads directly to contempt charges.
Appeal to Popularity (<i>Argumentum ad Populum</i>)	Arguing a claim must be true because the majority of people believe it.	Minority Control / Top-Down Dictatorship: The court's power does not rest on democratic consensus or majority vote, but on autocracy. Danforth and Hathorne dictate truth from above regardless of popular sentiment (which turns hostile by Act IV).

Pedagogical Summary & Analytical Takeaway:

Arthur Miller structures *The Crucible* to demonstrate that when a legal or political system replaces empirical evidence with subjective testimony ('spectral evidence') and ideological purity, logic inevitably fails. The fallacies in Salem are not accidental lapses in judgment—they are structural tools required to sustain an irrational witch hunt. Recognizing these patterns enables students to identify similar rhetorical collapses in contemporary public discourse and political hysteria.